

“We have agreed to move forward. We have developed a greater understanding in our friendship.”

S.M. KRISHNA, Foreign Minister

“Our relationship is at a new historic turning point. We will pass this friendship from generation to generation.”

DAI BINGGUO, State Councillor of China

KRISHNA WITH DAI BINGGUO: A SCENE FROM THE DANCE-DRAMA BASED ON THE LIFE OF EMPEROR ASHOKA HELD IN BEIJING (FAR RIGHT)



a wide range of areas. The boundary question should not be an obstacle to our relationship,” Dai Bingguo, the state councillor of China and the Chinese special interlocutor on boundary talks, told INDIA TODAY. What the top Chinese foreign policy czar, who rarely speaks to the media, said is significant. He was nicknamed “Mountain” by all his interlocutors because of his tough stand on the boundary issue. The talks were deadlocked after 13 rounds over differences in perception. New Delhi wants to maintain the status quo while Beijing insists on substantial concessions on the western sector in Arunachal Pradesh. With India fielding its new interlocutor Shiv Shankar Menon, the National Security Advisor, for the boundary talks, Dai’s statement indicates flexibility.

The chill in Beijing notwithstanding, the message was warm. “We agreed that let’s move forward. We have developed a greater understanding in our relationship. The vibes were quite positive,” Krishna told INDIA TODAY. The timing of the visit was crucial as it came after a disastrous 2009, when the relationship reached an alarming low:

the stapled Kashmir visa issue, the Dalai Lama and aggressive Chinese intrusions. The two sides desperately needed some urgent repair work. This visit seems to have done that. For a country steeped in hierarchy and secrecy, there seems to be a belated realisation that China is also losing out by delaying a breakthrough with its democratic neighbour. “After 60 years, our relationship is at a new historic turning point. We will now pass this friendship from generation to generation and will meet our goal,” said Dai.

Another sign of the thaw is the forthcoming high-level visits to broaden the engagement. President Pratibha Patil is slated to visit Beijing in May, and a boundary dialogue is expected soon. The two countries are also expected to meet on discussing counter-terrorism. “We consider it as the beginning of a new step-by-step approach in our relationship,” says Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao, whose last posting was as India’s ambassador to Beijing. But the cautious Rao knows it won’t be all that easy.

Earlier, the hotline deal was finalised after Krishna went through the draft of the agreement several times, but never missing his favourite idlis even in the Middle Kingdom. An anxious core team led by Rao and India’s Ambassador to China Subrahmanyam Jaishankar sat in a late night huddle in the presidential suite of Beijing’s trendiest hotel St. Regis to ensure that all was well.

The bilateral menu may not have had any surprise but the hosts had few surprises for the Indians at a joint event to mark the 60th anniversary of the diplomatic relations between the two countries. The most notable was the unexpected appearance of Dai. When Krishna suggested to Wen that the two foreign ministers of the countries meet every year, the Indian delegation did not expect to hear anything more than the usual “we will see” from the Chinese. Wen’s reply was: “Great idea, let’s do it.”

The atmospherics exuded a new bonhomie. China opened the forbidden city for the cultural extravaganza of the Festival of India. The dance drama based on the life of Emperor Ashoka was a huge hit. India will take its cul-